From housing approval to construction

How might we help residents and decision-makers understand what happens between a housing approval and construction, and where progress gets hard to track?

Build a working proof of concept that a municipality could realistically pilot. It can be a web app, data tool, map, dashboard or another format. A municipal leader should be able to use it without your team in the room.

The problem

Housing is one of the most pressing issues facing Canadian cities. Public debate often focuses on approvals: how quickly councils approve new homes and how many units they approve. But an approval is not a home. After approval, a project typically moves through further stages, such as site plan approval, conditions, financing, pre-sales, building permits, servicing and construction. Housing approval does not always lead quickly to construction. Residents and decision-makers need to understand the steps between them, where projects sit, and where progress becomes difficult to trace. Many approved units take years to break ground, and some never do. The reasons vary: interest rates, construction costs, market demand, servicing capacity, labour shortages and development charges among them.

For example, Toronto's Development Pipeline separates planning approval, permit application and permit-issued stages. A project counted as approved may still need other approvals. A building permit allows work to proceed, but issuance alone does not confirm that physical construction has started. [1]

Construction also depends on financing, labour, materials, servicing and market conditions. The Bank of Canada describes how borrowing costs and project viability can affect whether housing proceeds. Planning and permit records cannot reveal all of these conditions for an individual project. [2]

The pipeline between approval and construction is hard to see. Data sits in different systems: planning applications, building permits, servicing agreements and housing starts. These systems often use different identifiers, and some steps depend on private decisions that are not public at all. Without a clear view, residents may blame the wrong actor, and decision-makers may pull the wrong levers. Better tools could show where projects stall and why, so that policy responses target the real bottlenecks.

How common and persistent it is

- In the Greater Toronto and Hamilton Area, CivicAction counted 2,220 approved projects (about 1.2 million units) on hold in mid-2025, more than four times the number of active projects. That is roughly 12 approved homes for every one under construction.
- As of December 31, 2025, Toronto's development pipeline included approximately 297,000 residential units at the planning-approved stage and a further 65,000 at the building-permit-issued stage (City of Toronto's Development Activity Bulletin, 2025)
- Ontario housing starts hit their lowest level since 2009 in early 2025 (Financial Accountability Office). The province forecasts about 71,800 starts in 2025, well below the roughly 150,000 a year needed for its 1.5 million homes goal.
- 35 of Ontario′s 50 largest municipalities missed their 2024 housing targets (STOREYS, 2025).

Questions to investigate

- Which actors and decisions shape the transition from approval to construction, and which parts can a municipality influence?
- Where does visibility break between planning approval, permit application, permit issuance, construction start and completion?
- How should records be connected when projects have multiple phases, addresses, applications, permit revisions, and identifiers?
- What can public records reveal about timing and status, and what remains private or unobserved, such as financing, pre-sales, ownership or market demand?
- What other explanations could produce the same signal as a long interval, missing record or permit mismatch?
- How does uncertainty affect municipal planning, funding accountability, service delivery and public communication?

What it costs

- Housing affordability suffers as every stalled project is supply that isn′t reaching renters and buyers.
- Municipal funding as cities can lose provincial funding. Ottawa missed out on its Building Faster Fund allocation after reaching 63% of its 2024 target.
- Infrastructure costs when municipalities may build servicing for growth that doesn′t arrive on schedule.
- Trust can be eroded and blame can be incorrectly assigned when without shared data, municipalities, developers and the province point at each other.

Who you are designing for

Primary users. Residents waiting for housing and neighbours seeking to understand the status of approved developments.

Municipal users. Housing, planning and economic development staff tracking delivery and identifying projects that need follow-up.

Other stakeholders. Developers, non-profit housing providers, building officials, utilities, lenders and councillors. Provincial and federal governments funding and setting housing target.

What success looks like

- Users can follow projects through clearly defined approval, permitting, and construction stages.
- The tool connects project and unit information without counting the same development more than once.
- It highlights long intervals, missing milestones, and possible bottlenecks while distinguishing evidence from inference.
- A municipal leader can use the working tool independently to understand the pipeline and identify useful follow-up questions.

Constraints

- Keep milestones distinct. Planning approval, permit application, permit issuance, construction start and completion or occupancy are different events.
- Define projects, phases, and units consistently. Multiple addresses, approvals, and permit revisions can refer to the same development or to different phases.
- Use documented dates for intervals. An application received date is not an approval date, and a missing match is not proof of a construction delay.
- Separate evidence from inference. A long interval, missing record or permit status may warrant a question; it does not prove that a project has stalled or explain why.
- Respect what public data does not show. Financing, pre-sales, ownership decisions, labour availability, material costs and servicing capacity may be incomplete or private.

Public datasets to explore

You may use other public data that better supports your solution. Record your sources and dates, and make data limitations visible.

1. Development Pipeline (City of Toronto data and downloads)

Includes pipeline status, application number, date received, address, description, proposed residential units and links to planning records. It is a rolling snapshot rather than a complete milestone history; proposed units are not completed homes.

2. Building Permits Active Permits (City of Toronto data and downloads)

Includes permit and revision identifiers, work type, addresses, application and issue dates, status and dwelling-unit fields. It excludes cleared records, and permit issuance alone does not establish construction. Related permits can contain overlapping unit counts.

3. Application Information Centre (City of Toronto planning applications)

Provides current information on active Community Planning, Committee of Adjustment and Toronto Local Appeal Body applications. It refreshes daily, and closed applications may not appear.

Explain your thinking

Show who the tool serves, why you designed it this way and how you checked its outputs. Include clear instructions, source links and any assumptions. Explain what a municipality would need to test or add before piloting it. If you use AI, make its role and limitations clear.

Background sources

[1] City of Toronto. Development Pipeline

[2] Bank of Canada. Breaking down the costs of building new housing

[3] City of Toronto. Application Information Centre